

EXITING THE HERO TRAP

Shifting from Technical Expert to Post-Heroic Leader

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KEY TAKEAWAYS

One guide. Three ways to be in the room.

Whether you're at the Richmond Fed, watching with a group at a satellite site, or joining solo from your own screen — every activity in this session works for you. Built in, not bolted on.

THE SHIFT, IN THREE PARTS

Exiting the Hero Trap



The Problem

Naming the Hero Trap



The Inner Work

From Heroic to Post-Heroic



The Practices

What Helps the Shift

Heroic: "It's my job to find the right answers." → Post-heroic: "My job is to build a team with a common vision and mutual influence."

— Bradford & Cohen, *Power Up* (1998)

The shift isn't about doing less. It's about doing the right thing before you act — and building the conditions for others to solve it.

THREE WAYS TO BE IN THIS ROOM

Same Session, Every Seat

However you're joining, the activities are designed so you get the same experience — not a scaled-down version of it.



IN THE ROOM

You're at the Richmond Fed. Hands up for polls, pair with your neighbor, work the table exercises out loud.



WATCHING TOGETHER

You're with a group at a remote viewing site. Pair up and work the tables locally, just like the room — vote and share out over the same Slido link.



SOLO REMOTE

You're on your own screen. Every pair-and-share becomes a chat post; every private moment stays exactly as private as it is in the room.

Your Move, Wherever You Are

Six moments from the session, and exactly how each one works for the room, a remote viewing group, and solo remote attendees.

1

COLD OPEN + CLOSE · POLLS

The Two Polls

"Raise your hand if you were promoted into leadership primarily because you were excellent at your technical job. Keep it up if someone trained you to lead people before you needed to." (And again at the close: are you still sure the hero move is the safe move?)

IN THE ROOM

Hands up — the room's reaction is visible to everyone.

WATCHING TOGETHER

Hands up at your site, plus the shared Slido link for a real number.

SOLO REMOTE

Vote on Slido from your screen — same two questions, same live results.

2

PART 1 · INDIVIDUAL + PAIR · 5 MIN

The Cost of Being the Hero

Think of a real moment in the last month where you were the hero — you jumped in and solved it yourself. What did it cost your team?

IN THE ROOM

Write silently (90 sec), then pair with a neighbor (90 sec each way).

WATCHING TOGETHER

Same silent write, then pair with whoever's next to you at the site.

SOLO REMOTE

Same silent write, then drop your answer in chat — Braz reads a few aloud alongside the room's pairs.

3

PART 2 · SMALL GROUPS OF 3-4 · 5 MIN

Expert vs. Catalyst

Your team just missed a critical deliverable the week before a stakeholder demo. What do you do in the next hour?

IN THE ROOM

Split your table — half scripts the Expert response, half scripts Catalyst. Read both aloud.

WATCHING TOGETHER

Split your group the same way; smaller sites write both versions together.

SOLO REMOTE

Draft both versions yourself, then post one line of each to chat for the debrief.

4

PART 2 • INDIVIDUAL, SILENT, PRIVATE • 4 MIN

Your Own Slide Moment

One leadership behavior you know you should change. What are you afraid would happen if you did? Finish the sentence: "If I stopped doing this, people would know I ___."

IN THE ROOM

Private. Use the worksheet on page 6 — nothing is shared or collected.

WATCHING TOGETHER

Same — private, even sitting next to colleagues.

SOLO REMOTE

Same exercise, same privacy. Being remote changes nothing about this one.

5

PART 3 • SMALL GROUPS • 6 MIN

Sort It, Then Delegate It

Sort 4–5 scenarios into a 2×2: domain (known / not-known) × ownership (mine to solve / theirs to solve). Then draft an "I intend to..." sentence for one.

IN THE ROOM

Sort as a table, debate the placements out loud.

WATCHING TOGETHER

Sort as a group at your site the same way.

SOLO REMOTE

Sort on your own using the grid on page 6, then post your "I intend to..." line to chat.

6

CLOSE • COMMITMENT DEVICE

One Thing I'll Delegate This Week

Write one specific thing you'll delegate this week, using the "I intend to..." language.

IN THE ROOM

Index card — keep it, or hand it in for accountability.

WATCHING TOGETHER

Same — paper or a sticky note at the site.

SOLO REMOTE

Type it into chat, or use the worksheet on page 6. Same commitment either way.

FRAMEWORKS TO REMEMBER

The Four to Carry With You

The reference points from the talk worth keeping on your desk — or your desktop.



Joiner's Leadership Stages

Expert → Achiever → Catalyst. About 90% of managers lead heroically; about 10% reach post-heroic — Bradford & Cohen's term, which Joiner builds directly on.



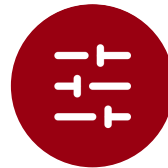
Two Lenses Before You Act

Cynefin: what kind of system is this — clear, complicated, complex, or chaotic? Heifetz: what kind of challenge, and whose work, is it — technical or adaptive?



"I Intend To..."

Marquet's language shift: turns a request for permission into a stated intention you approve. Try it this week.



Seven Levels of Delegation

Tell → Sell → Consult → Agree → Advise → Inquire → Delegate (Appelo). A dial you set per activity, not one global setting.

THE DEFECTS OF HEROIC LEADERSHIP

Bradford & Cohen, *Power Up*, pp. 40–41 — what it costs the team when one person carries all of it.

1

The leader shares too little information

2

Collective problem solving is discouraged

3

The leader alone holds the larger-unit perspective

4

The org has one "sensing unit" — everyone else's awareness atrophies

5

Over-focus on control inhibits initiative from below

Same Page, Literally

Use this whether you're writing by hand in the room or typing into your own note remotely.



Your Own Slide Moment

Private · not shared, not collected — Activity 4

1. One leadership behavior you know you should change.

2. What are you afraid would happen if you did?

3. If I stopped doing this, people would know I ____.

Not shared. Not collected. Yours.



One Thing I'll Delegate This Week

Commitment device — Activity 6

I intend to



Sort It, Then Delegate It

Domain × ownership — Activity 5

	KNOWN DOMAIN	NOT-KNOWN DOMAIN
MINE TO SOLVE		
THEIRS TO SOLVE		

Sources & Materials

ARTICLES & DATA

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Get the materials: full slides, source-document archive & activity handouts — <http://braz.coach/hero-trap>. Posted in chat for remote attendees at session start.